



a democratic government. This sounds unremarkable, until one thinks of the rest of Asia in the decades after World War II. Across Asia, two patterns emerged: zones wracked by civil or interstate war and a mosaic of authoritarian regimes. India, too, faced similar challenges; yet it managed to achieve a stable, inflation-free environment under an elected government. Without this feat, India's later development would have been impossible.

Three things that did not happen during the 1950s were equally consequential. First and foremost: the government failed to educate the citizenry. India began the decade with a mere 18 per cent of its population classed as literate; a decade later, the figure had increased by only 10 percentage points and 85 per cent of India's women remained illiterate. A useful comparison is China, whose per capita GDP in the 1950s was lower than India's. Although China began the 1950s with a literacy rate similar to India's, it made a concerted effort to educate women. Female literacy increased by around 3.5 per cent a year for much of the decade, and by the early 1960s, around 40 per cent of Chinese women were literate.

The 1950s set a long pattern for education—rhetorical attention, practical neglect. And even that attention was fitful. Nehru's huge prime ministerial correspondence contains astonishingly little sustained discussion of primary education. And it is sobering to realise that even when Maulana Azad headed the education ministry, the ministry lacked competence to utilise the monies allocated to it.

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A second missed opportunity was the inability to alter India's unequal distribution of land ownership. Again, a comparison with other Asian countries shows that in the countries that later enjoyed sustained economic growth, land reform was a pillar—a key precondition of the East and South East Asian economic miracles. India's land policy (like its primary education policy) was in the hands of the regional state legislatures. The 1950s, when the Indian National Congress controlled both the Central and state legislatures, was the optimal time to push through legislation. But the battle was evaded, and lost. The result was the forfeiture of a crucial instrument both to raise agricultural productivity and to effect economic redistribution, fundamental problems with which we still struggle.

A third failure was in the international realm. India's foreign policy during the 1950s is usually framed in the context of the Cold War's Soviet-American rivalry; many now criticise Nehru's policy of equidistance from the superpowers. In fact, this was very effective, given India's interests and meagre resources. The actual failure lay elsewhere—the inability to work out a positive regional stance. This is most clear in the case of Pakistan. The irresolution of the Kashmir dispute has kept the subcontinent the least integrated region of Asia and has blocked the region's economic development.

Still more important was the failure of India's China policy, the country with which we share our longest border. Nehru's China policy, in which he was so personally invested, suffered a slow deflation through the closing years of the decade. The policy's collapse in October 1962, when Chinese forces routed Indian troops, should have come as no surprise. The cloud which ever since has enveloped our relations with China has only just, and slowly, begun to dissipate.

It is striking how many of today's battles revisit the trenches of the 1950s. How should the economy work? What should be the role of the state? What are the terms of redistribution? What role shall we have in the world? The persistence of these questions is cause for frustration—but also reassurance. Beginning in the 1950s, we have accrued a body of experience from which we can learn, if we choose to learn. Authoritarian societies, committed to forgetting, obliterate their pasts. They live in a permanent present,

defined by the exercise of political will. Democracy is the most historical of political forms. Indeed, it is nothing else but history. And the 1950s launched us on a historical quest: to try to master our present by making whatever sense we can of our own cumulative choices. Our own history is the resource we have to draw upon to grasp our options, as we move forward.

The author is director of South Asia Studies at the Johns Hopkins University School of Advanced International Studies in Washington, DC.